

# Towards an epistemology of consumer culture theory: Phenomenology and the context of context

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## Abstract

This paper argues for an epistemological positioning of Consumer Culture Theory (CCT) research beyond the lived experience of consumers. CCT, it is argued, brought sociocultural context to consumer research, not least through the introduction of existential phenomenology as a paradigm for CCT studies. However, it is time to expand the contextualization of lived consumer experiences with another contextualization, this time the one of systemic and structuring influences of market and social systems that is not necessarily felt or experienced by consumers in their daily lives, and therefore not necessarily discursively expressed. There is a need to take into consideration the context of context. We therefore suggest an epistemology for CCT that explicitly connects the structuring of macro-social explanatory frameworks with the phenomenology of lived experiences, thereby inscribing the micro-social context accounted for by the consumer in a larger socio-historical context based on the researcher's theoretical insights.

## Keywords

consumer culture theory, context, epistemology, phenomenology, practice theory

## Introduction

The interest in cultural perspectives on consumption has risen significantly in the decades around the recent turn of the millennium. Consumption has moved from being either a matter of regenerating productive forces (sociology), maximizing utility (economics) or a process of acquisition (business studies) to become a term that seems to permeate the relations between society and

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individual, be it in the form of social classification and communications systems, identity formation processes, ritualistic and community building processes, the relationship between the individual and the state under the reign of new public management, or the search for existentially fulfilling experiences. A good number of sociologists and anthropologists as well as scholars from the field of cultural studies have flocked to the study of consumption, and the people hitherto most interested in the micro-social processes of consumption, consumer behavior researchers from the marketing discipline, have experienced a fundamental paradigmatic challenge to the prevalent econometric or cognitive social psychological approaches to consumption, a challenge labeled Consumer Culture Theory (CCT) by some of the most significant challengers (Arnould and Thompson, 2005).

The aim of this paper is to expand recent calls for more focus on broader analytical frameworks of CCT (Arnould and Thompson, 2005: 876). What we intend to argue, based on inspiration from trends within the field of cultural studies, is that in order for CCT to secure a position for itself, the best way of obtaining such a position is to 'blend theorization with grounded study' (Miller, 2007: 25). We are experiencing the institutionalization (cf. Arnould and Thompson, 2007) of CCT towards a synthesis of sociological, anthropological and cultural studies-derived insights into consumption; a market-attuned hybrid of social science which is by and large situated in business schools. The path towards an institutionalized establishment as a 'school of thoughts' (plural well intended) necessitates some reflections on its subject matter as well as its epistemological foundations. Naming is categorizing, and categorizing includes putting up boundaries, which *ipso facto* leads to processes of inclusion and exclusion. The (on its own terms fairly comprehensive) overview that provided the CCT label in the first place (Arnould and Thompson, 2005) has indeed been considered provocative by many, especially for its omissions and its alleged attempt to present a 'totalizing narrative' of one unified theory – criticized as a hegemonic vision of a highly diverse and polyphonic field of voices (Arnould and Thompson, 2007). We do not wish to participate in this debate, which appears from our perspective to be missing the point. In the contemporary marketplace of consumer research (cf. Peter and Olson, 1983) there are, as we see it, mainly benefits to be gained from gathering the forces under one particular label – as long as its purpose and effect is the establishment of an inclusive platform of dialogue rather than an exclusive guarding of dogma. The establishment of common ground beyond the loose paradigmatic assertion that this research is 'interpretive' (which research is not?), and the attempts to distinguish this group of research (and researchers) from other academic communities (e.g. sociologists or anthropologists of consumption), is crucial for scholarly identification, especially of doctoral students.

What knowledge does this field present? What is its reason for being? CCT obviously contributes to the noble and highly relevant process of securing culturally and socially informed environments at business schools, and thus contributes to 'capturing the markets from the economists' (Slater, 2002). But from our experience of cooperating with both sociologists and anthropologists of consumption, there is a need for bridging the analytical terrain between the anthropological search for thick description and deep immersion in the field, and the sociological inclination towards broad social theories and movements often quite remote from emic illustrations of everyday life experiences. Our intention here is to provide some reflections on the justification of CCT as a field that fills this gap by combining grounded observations and recordings of market-mediated and mediating practices with social theorization. These reflections will hopefully move forward the creation of an epistemology that is relevant to and supportive of CCT research, and possibly even demarcates the latter as distinct from other cultural approaches to consumption.

As in all social research, the discussion of the relationship between structure and agency has both inspired and haunted CCT research (depending on one's veneration for or fatigue with this central issue). As we later argue, approaches that stress consumer agency have been vital to the CCT tradition which can be said to be borne out of a dissatisfaction with too highly structured approaches to consumer behavior. It is not that the econometrically or psychologically based approaches to consumer behavior, to which CCT arose in opposition, did not apply a focus on the individual. But that individual was/is a consumer highly constrained by the assumptions of rationality and/or cognitive information processing, which underpin the ontology of these two other 'major pillars of consumer research' (Arnould and Thompson, 2007). Here, we must point to a paradoxical relationship between agency and consumer psychology. Psychology usually gives primacy to the agentic subject as the locus of power or intention. This excludes or at least relegates structural and contextual conditions to a secondary role. On the other hand, because of epistemological and methodological assumptions, that agency is restricted to a narrow universe. Agency, from an econometric or a behavioral decision theory perspective, is almost always relegated to a secondary position in relation to the controlled environment in which the consumer is situated, either through experimental design or through the pre-established universe of psychological categories presented by the survey instrument.

The consumer as a free agent is thus confined by the closed categories of the scales or the controlled environment of the experimental design. Consequently the orientation of much CCT research has been towards exploring a variety of contexts in which the consumer has been 'discovered' as an agent who draws upon market-based resources in constructing his or her own identity. Central to CCT research has been representation of the consumer subject as a reflexive and empowered identity seeker, navigating its way through the plethora of opportunities provided by the marketplace, and reflecting often both consciously and critically over the market mediated messages that embrace him or her.

Adding a micro-social level to the individual as a unit of analysis, research into consumer subcultures or brand communities (e.g. Schouten and McAlexander, 1995; Muniz, Jr and O'Guinn, 2001) has contributed to understanding the consumer not just as an identity seeker but also as a member of small-scale social unions. Contemporary consumer research has allowed itself to be inspired by French sociologist Maffesoli and his concept of a new tribalism (Maffesoli, 1988) and argued for the usefulness of the tribe in understanding consumer behavior from a collective subject perspective (cf. Cova et al., 2007). The well deserved attention paid to recent research on consumption communities actually serves, for the purpose of this article, to reinforce the impression that mainstream consumption research has not moved far from an individually focused paradigm: communities of consumption remain distinctly *that*, an epistemological exotica (Kozinets, 2001; Muniz, Jr and O'Guinn, 2001; Kozinets, 2002).

Additionally, we have recently seen a call for the study of 'connected consumers' or consumers as 'relational units', for instance in the form of dyadic, triadic or other micro-constellations of social unions (e.g. Epp and Price, 2008). This micro-social research, oftentimes drawing inspiration from subcultural analyses of the Birmingham School, has, however, had tendencies to assume somewhat teleologically that the consumption practices of such groups are consciously directed towards the construction of a shared collective identity, which although expressed in the terminology of symbols and identity, is nevertheless portrayed as a goal-directed endeavor much akin to personal identity projects. Not that there are not exceptions. In a compelling analysis of a set of brand communities, Schau et al. (2009) demonstrate the usefulness of the sociological notion of practices for understanding patterns of value creation that span different communities. The result

is a kind of catalogue over standard social processes that seem to characterize all or most of such micro-cultures.

The literature on brand communities and subcultures of consumption has underlined how consumer identity projects as well as their consumption patterns are highly bound by socially instituted factors of historical and cultural character. Most obvious, perhaps, is Murray's (2002) re-inquiry of Thompson and Haytko's (1997) study of fashion consumers, underlining the continued relevance of the politics of fashion despite agentic consumers' playful construction of personalized fashion expression. Other highlighting of social factors include for example the social construction of lifestyles (Holt, 1997); the role of ideology in the constitution of consumption (Crockett and Wallendorf, 2004); ideological framings of consumer 'empowerment' (Shankar et al., 2006; Zwick et al., 2008); applications of Bourdieu's concepts of capital and practice (e.g. Holt, 1998; Allen 2002); and the significance of social institutions for consumer-consumption relationships, for example in terms of social categories of the body (Thompson and Hirschman, 1995; Askegaard et al., 2002); class (Henry, 2005; Üstüner and Holt, 2010); masculinity (Holt and Thompson, 2004); technology (Kozinets, 2008); and youth (Kjeldgaard and Askegaard, 2006).

Luedicke et al. (2010) argued for the interplay of ideological and mythological forces in the construction of a morality of car consumption. Craig Thompson, who was among the initiators of the phenomenological tradition within CCT, has more recently been the most productive propagator for an ideological inscription of consumption phenomena. He has argued for the strong role of institutionalized marketplace mythologies in shaping the meaning systems ascribed to alternative medicine (Thompson, 2004) and in his and his co-authors' work on natural health communities – (Thompson and Troester, 2002); on communities of reflexive doubt (Thompson, 2005); on Community Supported Agriculture (Thompson and Coskuner-Balli, 2007); and on the commercial mythology of the American South (Thompson and Tian, 2008) – the ideological dimension is underlined time and again. These, and other, studies witness the acknowledgement with CCT research of the socialized nature of consumption beyond the lived experience of individual consumers.

Most certainly, then, broader analytical frameworks are not unknown even in the earliest CCT research (e.g. Levy, 1981; McCracken, 1986; Sherry, Jr 1983, 1990). Consequently, we are not arguing that we are paving completely new roads here; on the other hand, we do think that the aura of 'getting close' to the consumer still forms and informs many aspiring CCT scholars and, as already stated, we would like to propose an epistemology of CCT research which goes beyond lived consumer experiences. Furthermore, in spite of recent tendencies to go beyond the individual in explanations of consumer behavior, the majority of studies within CCT continue to focus on the individual consumer's meaning and identity projects.

The purpose of this paper is to further the development of a contextually (socially, culturally, politically and institutionally) oriented CCT research by providing a set of epistemological arguments for its usefulness. We aim to do this through a discussion of the emergence and strength of the highly individualized, experiential focus in most of the consumer research inscribing itself in the CCT tradition. We continue with a summary of some of the previously highlighted limitations of an individually centered approach in CCT. While we criticize the limited usefulness of existential phenomenology for the construction of knowledge of consumer behavior, we also recognize currents of phenomenological thinking inside and outside CCT that are explicitly or implicitly based on an epistemology that directs attention to the socially and culturally embedded consumer.

## The existential phenomenology legacy in interpretive consumer research

As pointed out by Tadjewski (2006b) in a compelling analysis, the birth of interpretive consumer research was rooted in motivational theory's application of an epistemology inherited from in-depth psychology and psychoanalysis. While Tadjewski underlines the fundamental similarity between epistemological and methodological foundations of motivational theory and interpretive consumer research, it is probably fair to point to the experiential and phenomenological focus as central in marking out the so-called 'interpretive turn' (Sherry, Jr, 1991) in consumer research of the 1980s. The experiential and naturalistic focus of the works of Holbrook and Hirschman, as well as the participants in the seminal consumer behavior odyssey (Belk, 1991), worked as a member-checked insurance against what had been conceived as the interpretive excesses of motivational theory. Referring back to Levy's (1959) call for attention to the symbolic nature of consumption, and drawing on the simultaneous paradigmatic debate in marketing theory (for an overview and critique, see for example Kavanagh, 1994), the field of consumer research developed a stream of projects and themes, all of which had as a paradigmatic assumption that human reality (or rather reality for humans) was not objectively given but always presented itself in the form of meanings, which had to be interpreted.

Thus, back then, the label interpretivism may have seemed more appropriate than now, almost 30 years later (cf. Arnould and Thompson, 2005). Initially, the term 'experiential consumption' (Holbrook and Hirschman, 1982) was often used to emphasise that this stream of research aimed at getting close to the lived realities of the consumer to extract the universe of meanings applied and constructed during the consumption processes. The most thorough example of such an existential approach to consumption was delivered by Belk in his now classical work on consumption and the extended self (Belk, 1988). Not long after, this new stream of research was identified with the social analytical tradition of 'existential phenomenology' in Thompson et al.'s (1989) seminal call for 'putting consumer experience back into consumer research'. This article, which we look at more closely below, as well as Thompson's (1997) later suggestion of an equally existential 'hermeneutical' approach, formed a standard reference for scientific approaches adopted by much CCT research in the decade-and-a-half to follow.

And this was quite rightly so, since the emphasis on phenomenology represented a strongly based reaction against the cognitivism of the information-processing paradigm (deemed unsuited by interpretivists as a scientific logic to study human behavior). It was a reaction against an overly abstract representation of consumers in consumer research, against what was seen as relatively futile attempts at operationalizing and measuring the immeasurable, and a reaction against methodological and conceptual efforts to vindicate the (in actual fact) highly implicated researcher and his or her research tools. The re-implication undertaken by phenomenological interpretivism exemplifies the general tendency of postmodern social science to scorn totalizing claims to scientific knowledge about social life, valorizing instead the 'positioned' researcher who creates admittedly subjective accounts and interpretations of the world (Haraway, 1988).

Hence, we see a historical pattern, where 'lived experiences' of 'real people' became the standard (pun intended) behind which flocks of consumer researchers could rally in the paradigmatic fight against the 'modellers' of the 'normal science view'. The focus on the individual is also very much in line with contemporary liberatory ideologies celebrating the modern individual's plethora of possibilities and resonating with the prevailing mythology of self-actualization. Furthermore, Arnould and Thompson (2005) find that of the four categories of CCT research, the

most voluminous in terms of publications is the one focusing on 'consumer identity projects'. Thus, the legacy of CCT research has been working towards a predominantly agency based view on the consumer, leading to a relative neglect of the structural foundations and limitations of the consumers' experiential universe.

### *Limitations of individually focused CCT research*

Consequently, when we look back on the development of what is now called CCT, the thought occurs that there have been some negative and unwanted consequences of the existential, phenomenological, hermeneutical or otherwise labeled focus. In a paradoxical way, its focus on consumer experiences can be said to have served as a continuation of the psychologizing tendency in consumer research that some of the founding fathers (and mothers!) strived to overcome. Only the more recent streams of research referred to in the introduction have begun to turn the tide, thus justifying the updated self-designation of the field: Consumer *Culture* Theory.

The continued predominance of the individual as a unit of analysis has been challenged by Moisander et al. (2009a), who argue that

It is important to be attentive to the specific representational systems – the socio-culturally normalized and institutionalized ways of thinking, talking and representing knowledge about the consumption agent, object or activity that are available and offered by the researcher to those being studied as resources for making sense of the topic in the specific context of the study. (Moisander et al., 2009a: 20)

In a parallel article, Moisander et al. (2009b) argue convincingly for the limitations of the individually and experientially based perspective on consumer culture, which follows from the phenomenological interview being the predominant method of data collection within CCT. Most importantly, they argue, such a perspective tends to downplay the more critical aspects in contemporary consumer culture, since such a critical approach is not an obvious part of consumers' lived experiences and thus does not appear in the phenomenological interview. To some extent, this echoes the insights provided by Holt (1991) concerning the problems of interpretive consumer research conducted under the guidance of the criteria of naturalistic inquiry, with its focus on objective criteria for evaluating research quality, such as member checking in order to secure trustworthiness. Such emphasis on the direct reflection of lived experiences is bound to narrow possibilities of interpretation. Holt, therefore, underlines the necessity of adding what he calls insightful interpretation. We would like to add, that although such interpretation is necessarily subjective, as Holt notes, it must also in order to constitute scientific insight be theoretically informed, in the way that it makes data speak to social and cultural context; by referring to existing theory or developing new analytical propositions.

We agree with Moisander and co-authors that for CCT research to progress beyond this one-sided attention to the self-realizing individual, new conceptualizations and models are required. Some of these can be found within sociology and anthropology, as mentioned above, while some originate within the CCT field, such as brand communities. But, and possibly more fundamentally, it also requires additional reflection on how researchers of the CCT field generally employ constructs such as ritual, status, traditions, symbolism and so on. Such constructs are often used by CCT researchers to describe how consumers construct meaningful universes for themselves by inscribing their practices of consumption in various social logics. However, such phenomena are not necessarily best understood from a social psychological perspective, i.e. as strategies for the

individual in terms of satisfying desires, defining selves, and constructing existences. If in the search for agents who construct meaning we continue to apply overly individualist perspectives, society cannot become much more than the aggregate of individuals' choices to engage in this ritual or that practice for the purpose of carving out an existence for him/herself. From a sociological perspective, the inverse causality should be just as dominant (at least) in our reflections on contemporary consumer culture. We have known at least since the days of Simmel that individual selves and intentions are functions of social and cultural practices, as pointed out by Østergaard and Jantzen (2000).

Miller shows how consumers' discourses about shopping as a hedonistic pastime negate their actual practice of daily shopping, which is characterized by a deeply socially embedded caring for present or hoped-for future relationships (Miller, 1998). But we are still reluctant to give up on the so hardly won respect for consumer agency. Are we so enamored of the empowered consumer that we dare not speak about socially structured determinisms? The call here is not to give up the study of consumer experience, but for situating acts of consumption, their motivations and consequences in a world that reaches beyond the subjectivity of the agent. What we need to include is a better understanding of the underlying ideological and mythological forces producing these subjectivities. Which forms of power produce particular forms of consumer agency? And what are the consequences for the relations between individual and society in particular contexts.

## **Epistemological supports for a more socially embedded CCT research agenda**

We would like to stress how our reflections here are rooted not so much in contemporary conditions of the experiential and reflexive consumer as in more fundamental anthropological considerations concerning the human condition and its epistemology. In order to provide some broader epistemological grounding for our ensuing reflections on practices and contexts as central concepts for research in consumer culture, we will initially draw on Douglas's (1986) theory of institutional agency.

As we have already evoked, part of our argument here is based on the shortcomings of interpreting consumer behavior exclusively or even predominantly in terms of the individual subject. We argue for the legitimacy of thinking in terms of collective subjects. This is why we turn to Douglas's theory of institutional agency. Douglas tries to establish a sociological epistemology based on the thinking of Emile Durkheim and Ludwik Fleck, in order to ensure that social facts are explained by other social facts rather than by being put through a psychological reductionism. Hence, her arguments are built up around a set of core cases of institutional agency, such as institutional remembering and forgetting, institutional categorizing, institutional decision making and not least institutions conferring identity. As such, and this is important for us to underline, social structures cannot be conceived as simply constraining an otherwise free individual. The social operations of institutional agency are enabling and constraining at the same time. Douglas embraced Fleck's notion of thought style (referred to as for example discourse, conceptual scheme or ideology by various other philosophers) to indicate the social formation of our individual expressivity. As Douglas (1986: 13) quotes Fleck for asserting: 'The individual within the collective is never, or hardly ever, conscious of the prevailing thought style which almost always exerts an absolutely compulsive force upon his thinking, and with which it is not possible to be at variance'. Based on Douglas's reflections, we would argue that it is crucial for the consumer

culture researcher to include an account of the institutional thought styles at stake in a particular field, well beyond the experienced lifeworld of the consumer.

Beyond the exceptions already mentioned, the general relative failure to include dimensions of institutional thought beyond and above consumer experiences may well at least partially be due to reviewer and editorial inclinations to substantiate all claims directly in consumer data. Paradoxically, CCT authors, reviewers and editors have to a large degree adopted Locke's famous empiricist conclusion that nothing is in the mind which was not first in the senses – with the significant addition that we are talking about the senses of the consumer subject under investigation. Furthermore, in our search for the concrete consumer experiences rather than more abstract patterns, we have introduced a tendency to avoid certain consumption phenomena that do not readily lend themselves to consumer reflection. Some types of consumption are deeply inscribed in less reflexive consumption practices, for instance the consumption of water, electricity and similar goods (Gronow and Warde, 2001). In spite of the importance of the latter consumption areas for social and economic policy, their study is still largely left to utilitarian approaches.

It therefore makes sense to take a closer look at the practice turn in contemporary theory (Schatzki et al., 2001) and its consequences for marketplace activities (e.g. Kjellberg and Helgesson, 2007; Andersson et al., 2008) and for consumption (Warde, 2005).

### *Consumption as practice: Individual experience and social constraints*

It should be an assumption on the part of any researcher investigating consumer *culture*, that while the consumer perceives his or her actions, desires and intentions as directed specifically to circumstances in the life of themselves or their close peers, these drivers of consumption to a large extent originate in cultural, societal, economic and political conditions. This does not mean doing away with accounting for the individual worldview. But we argue that it is imperative to regard consumption as *practice*. Among other theoreticians of practice (e.g. Giddens, 1979), the conceptual toolbox of Pierre Bourdieu is well suited for this calibration of our epistemological apparatus (Bourdieu, 1972 [2007]; Bourdieu, 1984). As consumers act to maximize material, symbolic and social capital within various types of fields, they may experience themselves as under no particular constraint from rules or obligations. But this is exactly the point of the concept of *habitus*; that the social actor possesses an embodied, pre-reflective competence, having internalized the rewards and sanctions that stem from surrounding social structures, which are thus not the object of direct reflection. There is indeed a tendency for *misrecognition* on the part of social actors, Bourdieu says, as the latter are neither able nor willing to recognize that their practices follow and reproduce social rules for an everyday 'economic' maximization of capital in their culture and social fields. This tendency obviously casts into doubt the adequacy of any research that simply reiterates the claims to individual uniqueness and free self-realization made by consumers; a valid analysis should also point to the social constraints and cultural continuities which, from an analytical viewpoint, manifest themselves in consumer practice. This does not mean that there is social determinism; consumer practice is conditioned by external structures, but it also works back on these structures, changing them through acts of improvisation. These acts arise continually in that actors never face a completely predictable outcome of the social symbolic exchanges in which they engage, and because social rules are always abstract, never prescribing specifically the conduct that will lead to a desired outcome in any social situation. The analysis of practice thus encompasses the reproduction of social boundaries that is simultaneous with the ongoing

formulation of strategies by actors, their improvisation in the face of unanticipated consequences and ambiguous responses, and their experience of self-actualization, creativity and rebellion.

The benefit of the Bourdieuan approach for consumer research is not primarily that it makes it possible for consumer researchers to order their empirical material by dividing it into social fields and kinds of capital, although such attempts at neat analytical mapping seem to dominate much CCT usage of Bourdieus work. Its real strength, however, lies in the epistemology that underwrites concepts such as *practice*, *habitus* and *misrecognition*. We do not argue that any analysis of consumption should necessarily utilize specific Bourdieuan concepts; but the basic analytical stance to social life that the latter represent serves any analysis of consumption well by safeguarding it from the worst excesses of liberatory ideology and overly individualist epistemologies, adding a certain analytical distance to consumers' own accounts of their reasons for acting.

### **A more contextually oriented consumption research**

We are appealing for CCT research to pay increased attention to the contexts that condition practices of consumption. While 'context' is sometimes invoked in research on consumer culture, the term itself has not received much specific attention. Most profoundly, Arnould et al. (2006) discuss the significant processes of selecting a rewarding context for gaining theoretic knowledge about marketplace phenomena. Their insightful chapter itself is witnessing the preoccupation with the micro-social context of CCT research, even if these authors underline the dangers of over-contextual absorption both for researchers and readers of research output. But what is 'context'?

A common understanding of contextualization is that it implies appealing 'to features and characteristics surrounding a phenomenon in order to illuminate it and to understand or give sense to it' (Dilley, 1999). Dilley explains that appeals to context can be distinguished as different kinds of contextualizing moves, of which the main three are:

1. External context: Articulating 'a connection between one domain of phenomena ... and another' such as the social life of a group, or wider societal or global structures and processes surrounding the phenomenon (Dilley, 1999: 12).
2. Internal context: Connections *within* the domain of the phenomenon under study. An illustrative example concerns spoken language, where the meaning of one part of an utterance exists only in relation to other parts of the same utterance. The overall meaning of the full utterance also involves the social and material contexts of the speaker that were referred to above as 'external'.
3. Psychological or mental context is the third most common analytical reference, and marks 'a shift in attention in the study of meaning from the relationship between signs and the things they signify in the world towards a focus on the minds of sign-users and their intentions as inner states' (Dilley, 1999: 13).

An example of early CCT research that includes the three types of contexts mentioned above is that of Belk et al. (1991) analyzing the symbolic meaning of collecting and collections. Psychological or mental context is invoked when describing collectors as people who are intent in creating some small measure of perfection in a world indifferent or scornful to their plight, or who immerse themselves in the collection as 'a new realm of experience [where they] can potentially experiment with a fantasy life' (Belk et al., 1991: 25). Internal contextualization is used when emphasizing seriality: how objects such as nutcrackers have no intrinsic meaning as use or aesthetics but solely in relation to other objects, with which they must share some similarity. External contexts referred to are for

example the ‘heightened acquisitive and possessive orientation that epitomizes the modern consumer “culture”’ (Belk et al., 1991: 20), and the act of collecting is seen as ‘an immersion in acquisitiveness, individualism, competitiveness, and display of personal accomplishments through material objects – all central values in American culture’ (Belk et al., 1991: 42).

We can thus restate our argument here as one that goes against the overly individualist focus of some consumption research relying mainly on psychological or mental context. We concur with Dilley that this approach has little relevance for a fieldwork based discipline. As argued above, phenomenological approaches must go beyond such tendencies, and we have referred to several that satisfy this requirement.

To which contexts should consumption research pay attention? Is it enough to have some kind of context, even if it does not include relations to other human beings? At the risk of contradicting (but hopefully nuancing) our main argument about the socially embedded consumer, we recognize that in understanding the meaning of objects to consumers, one does not necessarily have to foreground the social constructions and values that reside in the surrounding social sphere. Material layouts and ecological conditions are also relevant contexts. Some very interesting perspectives along the lines of ‘object agency’ have appeared in the works of scholars who, while also invoking contexts such as the ideologies of society and the agency and intention of consumers, pay close attention to the consumption object itself as primary context, while also bringing into play the ideologies of society and the agency and intention of consumers (Borgerson, 2005). A potential for a certain consumer–object relation can reside in the make-up of the very object itself, such as the ability of some objects to ‘reveal themselves progressively’ and in the process engage the consumer in an intersubjective relation with the object (Zwick and Dholakia, 2006); or in the role that material spaces, such as those of the home, have in determining consumers’ consumption habits (Coupland et al., 2005). Even if the evident cultural and historical variation in the meaning of signs suggests that the latter is arbitrary (Mick, 1986), there is something to be said for acknowledging the role of material object functions and ecological conditions in structuring consumer experience and practice by influencing the horizon of possible meanings and outcomes.

A hugely important discussion about the relation between subject and object underlies this issue, which at some point needs to be resolved with the social constructivism that underwrites the notion of consumer culture. A growing number of scholars are considering how experiences central to some consumer practices, such as sensing the atmosphere of a place, are constituted by material properties, the effect of which is to some extent not a matter of cultural coding or discursive framing. Some authors criticize semiotics, hermeneutics and discourse analysis for not comprehending material objects and settings in their immediacy; in how they come forth as a bodily sensation of presence, but only as signs, the meaning of which is constituted in relation to other signs, and perceived by the subject’s mind (Ingold, 2000; Gumbrecht, 2004; Miller, 2010). Miller asserts that it is wrong ‘to treat body praxis as a mere vehicle for the outward expression of meanings emanating from a higher source in culture or society’ (Miller, 2010: 169). The analytical challenge posed from that direction is to conceptualize the role of an object ‘in the ways in which it goes forth from itself’ (Böhme, 1992: 121).

It is a sobering notion that not any and all meanings can be arbitrarily attached to any given consumer good, as some unsuccessful attempts at branding may remind us. But in spite of such advances in terms of understanding how meanings may emanate from the immediate material make-up of the object, an overwhelming body of research in anthropology and sociology suggests the primacy of social context. So while consumption research may progress by paying increased attention to consumers’ involvement with the material world, and not only with market meanings

in the pursuance of identity construction, these foci must be situated within an attention to the larger social and cultural context.

Now clearly, much research into consumer culture *does* go beyond 'mind as context' and take as epistemological point of departure that consumption objects and practices signify something in the world. But still there is a lack of adequate attention to *social and cultural context* in many analytical works, which focus instead on the agency of consumers and their identity projects. These invoke mainly *psychological context*, as mentioned above, for analyzing the symbolic meanings of consumer goods, and the emotions and preferences of consumers.

## Roots of the individualizing tendency in phenomenological consumer research

We are now better equipped to return to our initial argument. Our critique extends to those studies of consumption that go beyond the psychological level, and do pay attention to economic and social conditions of the consumers' everyday life, but still confine themselves to the context of their own empirical data. This usage of context, which would be called internal in the terminology of Dilley, is prevalent in phenomenological CCT-related research, as we argue in this section. Because the tradition of phenomenology has been a driving force in the CCT focus on experience, we will take a closer look at the beginnings of CCT phenomenology; the analytical ambitions that it initially held and how these relate to the present challenges of contextualization facing CCT. We also look briefly at later CCT-related works that explicitly place phenomenology in the foreground of their analytical approach. In other words, it is time to revisit the already stated critique of CCT phenomenology in the light of the various levels of context.

While the 'phenomenological approach' referred to in CCT works of the 1990s and 2000s often employ a de-contextualizing, individualizing perspective, this is not necessarily the direction pointed out by the programmatic article by Thompson et al. (1989). That article warns against fragmenting consumer experience into independent analytical elements. Such a call for holism can be seen as an argument for contextual analysis, especially when the article argues that we should seek to 'describe experience as it emerges in some context(s)' (Thompson et al., 1989: 135), thus criticizing the analytical abstraction of consumers' knowledge from the context that it is attuned to.

A further promise of contextual awareness lies in the notion of figure/ground: while the article is of course highly attentive to consumer experience, it is also adamant that what draws the attention of consumers is never independent of background; the two co-constitute each other. Elements of context exert an influence on the awareness of the consumer and may suddenly impress themselves as text, a shifting that is itself crucial to consumer experience, as the article suggests. That particular part of the article does not directly concern cultural and social context; it is more psychologically concerned with the dynamics of attention. But it implies an analysis of what 'ground' is, which suggests some sort of contextual understanding.

However, when practiced in CCT-related research, actual phenomenological approaches seem to be more concerned with interrelating the various parts of consumer experience, than with placing that phenomenon in a wider social and cultural context. This tendency emerges in the study of the consumption experience of mothers published by Thompson et al. in 1990, shortly after their call for a phenomenological consumer research. In the introduction we are briefly reminded that in the US society of that time, there is a feminist movement that relates to increasingly egalitarian marriages. The remainder of the article refers only to what we might call the internal context of the study at the individual level: the financial situation of informants, the structure of their family,

their expressed personal feelings about shopping and habits as a consumer, the social side of their shopping with friends and family, and their own attempts at changing their ways of shopping. By interrelating these different domains of individuals' experience of consumption and everyday life, the article arrives at a compelling interpretation around consumers' attempts at controlling their shopping: 'within the context of a perceived crisis, Samantha experiences freedom from the responsibilities of shopping alone' (Thompson et al. 1990: 351, emphasis added). While the interpretation of *freedom within crisis* most likely goes beyond what the informant herself would be able to state, the range of social phenomena drawn on for interpretation remains narrowly confined to those that the consumer herself points to as relevant, and which readily lend themselves to interpretation within the data set collected for the specific analysis.

Thus the two founding works of phenomenological CCT do not move beyond the subjective horizon of the consumer in their analytical approach, even if they show an awareness of the necessity to contextualize consumers' lived reality. *The consumer experience becomes at once both text and context*: various elements of the consumer experience, which are in themselves analytical 'text', become the context for other elements of that selfsame consumer experience (even if the descriptive range of that experience is widened considerably compared to measurements of experience fragments undertaken in the labs of consumer behavior psychologists). The studies we are reviewing here do interrelate different elements of consumer subjectivity in a way that represents a certain dynamic of text and context, but almost exclusively within a horizon confined to phenomena that stand out within the set of interview data as such. What are missing are the various external contexts for consumers' efforts to exercise control over their shopping, such as modern individualism and the middle-class morality that makes a carefully managed economy and a sense of personal style important ways to gain social respect. These contexts are active when consumers navigate, appropriate, reproduce and challenge 'consumer culture'. External contexts relevant for a study of family shopping would also be those analyzed in more recent works by Miller and others on the historical changes around the western family; away from patriarchal power and status towards the sacralization of the child (Miller, 1998) and the societal moralizing and monitoring of relations between parent and child rather than those between spouses (Gullestad, 1992; Gullestad and Segalen, 1997; Howell and Melhuus, 2001).

If we look at the CCT-related studies that have followed since Thompson and his co-authors' call for a focus on consumer experience, and which explicitly refer to themselves as phenomenological, we see that the meaning of 'phenomenological consumer research' varies for its early practitioners. It differs to which extent the phenomenological approach draws on context. Mick and Demoss (1990) refer to Thompson and his co-authors in embracing 'the emphasis in the phenomenological paradigm on examining context-embedded human experience', which in 1990 would have signified a move out of the lab and closer to the real-life experience of consumers. In their analysis of self gifts the authors make brief reference to the 'Western Protestant ethic' that finds its full realization in the American ethos of achievement and reward. But apart from that, interpretation again unfolds within the horizon of the data set. It seems common for consumer research that declares itself as phenomenological to confine itself in this way to the data collected among a few individuals, and use those as the basis for finding correlations that suggest segments or personality types of consumers. These works seem to assume that by taking a 'phenomenological approach' one is licensed to making merely a broad, emic, non-theoretical description of a phenomenon. This research seems to be unaware of the analytical potential that phenomenology holds, instead seeing 'phenomenological description' merely as a precursor to theoretical explanation.

Often the aim of such phenomenological description is to judge whether a phenomenon fits into predefined concepts. This results in a fragmentation of consumer experience that does not satisfy the phenomenological criterion of holism and interrelation set out by Thompson et al. By fragmenting the topic into predefined conceptual categories, as a precursor for controlled measurements and comparisons, the research loses sight of all larger existential issues around consumer experience, not to say those of consumer culture (e.g. O'Guinn and Faber, 1989; Bergadaà, 1990).

This tendency towards fragmentation is also criticized in more recent CCT-related works that declare themselves to be phenomenological. Cotte et al. complain that 'a focus on isolated facets has likely hindered the growth of more in-depth knowledge on timestyles and their interrelations with consumer behavior' (Cotte et al., 2004: 333). We see here the phenomenological spirit of de-fragmentation that also appeared in the early phenomenological works of Thompson et al. Cotte et al. (2004) refer to more and wider contexts than those seen in earlier phenomenological works, such as the pervasiveness of time management in the American 'market system'; the history and evolution of the Western notion of time as something that is measured by a clock; American cultural norms of self-improvement; and modern Western culture as such resting on a foundation metaphor of 'time is money'. Yet while more contexts are referred to, this is done in an extremely cursory manner that rarely adds societal and cultural perspectives to the analysis but merely suggestive hints. Moving mainly within the confines of the authors' own empirical material, the analysis instead focuses on differences between individuals interviewed, and on that basis tries to arrive at a segmentation that seems rather strained from both a quantitative and qualitative point of view. The analytical choice of aligning different orientations towards time with different individual personalities is an unhappy one, from the perspective of understanding consumer culture. There is a strong risk of losing sight of consumer culture in this penchant for shaky segmentations and essentialist perspectives on individual consumers. A true phenomenological focus on consumer culture might instead look at the coexistence of different orientations within cultures and also within individuals, for whom they can create tensions or function as different modes of perception and self-presentation across a range of everyday situational contexts.

### *Phenomenology and the limits of ethnography*

In the phenomenological CCT-related works mentioned above, we often get an in-depth, empathic understanding of consumer experience, seeing consumption truly through the eyes of the consumer. But it is also clear that the influence of phenomenology on consumer research often amounts to a decoupling from societal and cultural context. The analytical gaze turns inwards towards the experience of the individuals that were interviewed for the research. Thompson et al. argue that 'thematic meanings stand in relation to each other and that the total quality of experience emerges from such interrelationships' (1990: 359). This is not to be argued with, but the question is: How narrow or wide a spectrum of relationships should be included in the analysis? We argue that the range of these meanings should encompass dimensions such as culture, society, ecology, materiality and history. Some might argue that we would lose sight of the specificities of consumer culture if we were to refer to the broader social structures and processes that are the subject of various basic disciplines. There is a point in that argument, because when for example Thompson et al chose not to refer to historical and ideological changes around family life in the Western world, or middle-class morality, one may say that they invoked instead the one context that consumer research is concerned with: consumer culture as such. However, it will help any CCT study in communicating how specific are its findings to consumer culture, if the researcher

considers how his or her particular slice of consumer culture is influenced by or varies from local culture, ideological conditions, social structures and present historical conditions. A wider contextual awareness would provide consumer research with a cross-cultural sensitivity that could transcend the heavy bias of the American middle-class perspective in our understanding of consumer culture. It would give consumer researchers a more advanced approach to prioritizing certain analytical connections, and also allow them to draw conclusions of a wider analytical reach, by which they could enter a dialogue with the basic disciplines of the human and social sciences.

However, researchers that identify with the CCT field still submit works totally devoid of references to the nationality, gender, age, geographical location, political leanings, etc. of the informants in question. They are just 'consumers' and the ill-defined context referred to is 'consumer culture' – often without accounting for any cultural dynamics and norms that would be specific to 'consumer culture', apart from long established notions such as the 'extended self' that pertain to consumers' identity projects.

As we have suggested several times in this paper, some CCT work shows a propensity to turn inwards, towards one's own data, a drift which relates to the individualizing and decontextualizing tendency that is rooted in a particular usage of phenomenological thinking. This happens at the expense of a dialogue with consumption research undertaken within other disciplines, and it also impedes the critical, creative reinterpretations of other researcher's data that are crucial to theoretical innovation in any field. Such closure has not decreased with the increasing popularity of ethnographic methods, in spite of all the other benefits of the latter. We agree with Holt (Holt, 2003) that for the understanding of consumers and markets that CCT and for which other disciplines strive, cultural analysis is a necessary analytical tool for charting the fluctuations and contradictions in the ideologies of a society, which provides answers that do not as such depend on a particular set of empirical material collected through ethnography or other methods. Cultural and social dynamics are legitimate points of analysis even if they are not immediately apparent in informants' utterances and practices. However, the venturing of more far-reaching analytical perspectives is curtailed by the fetichization of empirical data that appears again and again in CCT research.

## **A phenomenological approach to social context**

As mentioned above, the phenomenological influence on CCT is partly responsible for the tendency of the latter to give priority to individual psychology at the expense of social context. This critique however does not imply that psychologizing is an inherent weakness of phenomenological analysis, but rather that this is how phenomenology has been operationalized in consumption research. Indeed, some currents of phenomenological thinking distinguish themselves by taking as their point of departure the fundamentally social nature of human existence, analyzing how individuals merge their worldviews and participate in each other's experiences, and how their constructions of identity represent cultural and historical continuities in dealing with the boundary between the particular and the universal. These phenomenological approaches resonate with our call for a context-attentive epistemology. Within the hermeneutic endeavor of interpretation, they are more attentive than other phenomenological approaches to the 'whole' side of the dialectic of part and whole, that is, to the larger context of experience. They retain the detailed description of experience, but also refer to extra-experiential contexts on theoretical and methodological grounds.

In his writings on phenomenological anthropology, Michael Jackson uses the concept of *intersubjectivity* to denote the fundamental traits of mutuality, interconnectedness and negotiation

that characterize human existence. The concept posits that an ongoing social process of give and take among subjects is always adjunct to their experience of being in the world (Jackson, 1996; Jackson, 1998). We inhabit a social field where our identities and selves are continually under formation through processes that include shared experience and mutual empathy, but also ongoing negotiation, conflict, and individual struggles to resist or dominate each other. For all cultures 'it is possible to outline a domain of action and understanding in which people expect to be able to grasp, manipulate, and master their own fate' (Jackson, 1998: 19). In that perspective, consumption practices like other everyday actions can be seen as attempts at navigating the uneasy relationship between the particular and the universal. In that context, one phenomenological approach might be to ask what kind of goods are perceived to support vs threaten one's control of the border between everyday life and the world beyond. Taking such an analytical stance to social practice enriches CCT by grounding it in a deeper understanding of both the universal existential parameters of social life, and the particulars of culture. CCT has a unique potential to provide a particular analytical understanding of modernity by investigating how acts of consumption facilitate the universal intersubjective endeavor of seeking 'a balance between the world one calls one's own and a world one deems to be not-self or other' (Jackson, 1998: 18). Moving between these worlds, playing them off against each other, negotiating their boundaries – this constitutes the central dynamic of human action to which the concept of intersubjectivity refers. The 'existential' thus cannot be analytically decoupled from the social. This mode of phenomenological thinking clearly resonates with a consumption research that draws upon sociology and anthropology in seeing the individual experience of consumption as constituted within reciprocal relations between the individual and its social groups, the materiality, and the wider fields of society, culture and state.

Understanding consumption as a social act, and the dynamics of communities of consumption, is also facilitated by a phenomenology that sees individuals as socially embedded, such as that of Schutz (1970). Psychologists have used his *thesis of the alter ego* as a way to escape the monadism that looms large in the field of psychology (Auburn and Barnes, 2006). Schutz conceptualizes how in a 'reciprocal witnessing' between individuals, each individual relates to the experience of the situation by the other, and a 'we-relationship' arises (Schutz, 1970: 32). Thus in people's experience, e.g. of material objects of consumption, other people's viewpoints upon those objects are implicated, and so is the assumption of the inner life of these other people. Individuals do not reflect over this complex dynamic, which in everyday moment-to-moment consciousness collapses into what is experienced as one; which is another reason why any profession on the part of our informants of 'making my own choices' has to be approached with a healthy dose of analytical attention to context.

If these examples of context-aware phenomenology sound like they are attuned to individual psychological and existential issues, let it be said without a doubt that all phenomenology has an inherent inclination towards methodological individualism (Overgaard and Zahavi, 2009). But this does not preclude phenomenological thinkers from focusing on social embedment, as exemplified in this section by the intersubjective perspectives of Jackson and Schutz's, attention to dialogic interweavings between cognition and the social world. The bottom line is that CCT tendencies towards solipsism are a needless consequence, even if one makes the legitimate analytical choice of utilizing a phenomenological approach and place individual experience at the centre.

What this discussion also suggests is that as researchers, our choice of conceptual tools cannot be separated from questions of ontology and even ideology. As we have stated above, overly individualist epistemologies in consumption research may be influenced by a liberalist ideology of

self-emancipation. With each analytical concept that one employs, one also implies an answer to fundamental ontological questions such as: What is the 'state of nature' of man as a social animal? How does the self develop? How does human cognition work? Is there free will? We argue for a more contextually sensitive epistemology that emphasizes the social structuration of consumer practices and how all ideals, whether individualist or not, reside in a collectively shared imaginary.

### *Towards a context of context*

It is a legitimate analytical strategy to represent consumer as being motivated by their 'identity project'; but if the analysis aims for an elucidation of 'consumer culture', it should acknowledge the cultural, historical and societal conditions that make this identity and the means of attaining it attractive and legitimate in the first place. While some consumption research offers compelling ethnographic accounts of everyday face-to-face interactions among consumers in 'close contexts', such as brand communities or families, and while we want to retain that focus on 'close social context', we argue also for being attentive to the *context of contexts*: societal class divisions, historical and global processes, cultural values and norms.

The task of contextualization is to explain consumers' choices by referring both to the structuring force of such large-scale contexts, and the meaningful projects that arise in everyday sociality. It is in their everyday social context that society's norms are made relevant to people; this is where they become concrete and manifest themselves as a form of lived ideology. But the task of the consumption researcher is to balance the understanding of this face-to-face immediacy and the subjective concerns of the consumer with the way that cultural, societal and historical structures and processes embed these intersubjective dynamics.

The need to contextualize contexts becomes especially acute when we look at communities of consumption that are highly responsive to, and the subject of, cultural norms, juridical structures and direct political intervention. One such community would be the family. Rather than merely assuming the primordial need for families or dyads within families to have 'identity', analyzing the role of consumption in constructing family identity (Epp and Price, 2008) begs the question of what role the kinship norms of culture and the prevailing ideologies of society play in specifying who can call themselves 'a family', envisioning how households should ideally be structured, and naturalizing family structures and values. Paying attention to such dynamics is not necessarily meant to imply a politically charged critique of values and ideologies, but rather as an advance towards more satisfactory accounts of why certain practices of consumption unfold like they do, using theoretical tools that make us able to comprehend the structuring effect of culture and ideology. Looking at the ways that everyday consumption practices reproduce larger cultural and social frameworks is also a matter of asking not only how consumption is influenced by social forms and processes, but how it participates in the constitution of society.

Of course there is a limit to the range of contexts that can and should be referred to. There are always other, larger, even more external contexts that impose themselves as relevant. As Dilley says 'Context suffers the ... problem of infinite regress of contextualizing, contextualizing contexts and so on' (1999: 16). It will always be an analytical choice to cordon off a part of the analytical field and present it as a contextual domain. Furthermore, dependence on context is a kind of limited relativism, which can in the extreme lead to a particularism that makes subjects of study analytically incomparable, by encapsulating them within their respective unique and intricate connection to context. Since making certain connections always implies making disconnections,

which are ultimately an analytical choice, we suggest that the task is to present this choice as a conscious one, and let it be the subject of scholarly debate.

## **Concluding thoughts: Towards an epistemology of consumer culture theory**

Contemporary epistemology sustains the notion that knowledge does not directly reflect reality but is a theoretical structuration of it. Furthermore, given the interdisciplinarity of CCT, we must operate with a complex constellation of plural theoretical structurations. The present paper is not an attempt to hegemonize any particular theoretical or empirical approach. It is an attempt to carve out an epistemological space for an emerging field of CCT. This epistemological space is neither deeply phenomenological in the anthropological tradition of emic descriptions of contextualized social phenomena, nor is it sociologically 'grand' theorization on a more aggregate level, although it contains elements of both of these. Compared to sociologies of consumption, the strength of CCT has always been the inclusion of rich and detailed accounts of real-life experiences of consumers as single persons or in small groups. On the other hand, as we have discussed, this has led to negligence of those (predominantly social) elements of forces shaping consumer lives that are not necessarily part of ordinary consumer experiences. This phenomenologically inspired empiricism is in constant risk of falling subject to the fallacy described by Louis Dumont: 'In social science in general, it is a fallacy to claim, as it is often done, that traits, elements, or individuals are more tangible than sets or wholes' (Dumont, cited in Bouchet, 2007: 32). The focus on lived experiences should not lead CCT to repeat the individualizing tendencies of the remainder of the consumer research community. Experiences are individualized, but the element of 'lived' draws our attention to the conditions under which these experiences unfold, conditions that are not necessarily experienced *per se*. In that case, we miss the specificity of the social. As noted by Bouchet (2007: 43), 'the identification within the social of a space beyond intentionality means the possibility to reflect upon the complexity of the social bond'.

The epistemology of CCT as it is emerging from the best of the work produced by CCT scholars is exactly that analysis of consumer lifeworlds, which takes into account the influences of social forces beyond personal rationality or irrationality. The focus on market systems as promoted through the more recent work of Craig Thompson is one example. CCT is at its best a fruitful encounter between a rich context and solid theory – but it is usually not content to let knowledge emerge solely from the field (as in some anthropological traditions). Insight into the complex intertwining of the individual and the social in consumption contexts as it manifests itself in consumer lives and life conditions is, for us, the axis around which an epistemology of CCT is built up. The social always speaks through the consumer – with or without the consumer's awareness. 'I am in the world that is in me', explains French sociologist and philosopher of science Edgar Morin on several occasions.

Morin's dictum, as well as the double nature of social structure as enabling and constraining, is reminiscent of Morin's dialogical notion of complexity and his notion of the uni-duality of thought (Morin, 1986; cf. also Kofman, 1996). This uni-duality is best expressed through the dialogic, a recursive relationship between two concurrent and antagonistic parts, which as a model is a constitutive element in Morin's philosophy of complexity. Unlike dialectics, none of the conflicting logics is resolved but remains co-constitutive each of the other. Examples of such a dialogic, of which Morin's writings are replete, are relations between body and mind (and the related empiricism–rationalism dialogic), or individual and society. Morin (1986), in a discussion of the

|                   |                           |                   |
|-------------------|---------------------------|-------------------|
| Subjectivism      | Comprehension/explanation | Objectivism       |
| Unintelligibility | Concrete/abstract         | Disincarnation    |
| Subjectivism      | Participation/detachment  | Incomprehension   |
| Arbitrariness     | Analogic/logic            | No creativity     |
| Arbitrariness     | Imagination/verification  | No invention      |
| Drifting          | Uncertainty/certainty     | Dogmatism         |
| Confusion         | Blurring/precision        | Abstract rigidity |

**Figure 1.** The dialogic of knowledge and its pitfalls (excerpt from Morin, 1986: 184)

anthropology of knowledge, argues that the process of thinking and thus the formation of knowledge takes place in a series of dialogical relations between different mental operations. These may be summarized in the overarching dialogic of comprehension, an empathic mode of knowledge close to *Verstehen* in the Weberian sense of the term, and explanation, referring to a logical-rational-empirical style of knowledge. The dialogic represents an open reasoning, where any attempt to ignore the complexity of the uni-duality of thought will lead to totalizing and dogmatic visions of the world. For example no thinking is possible without rationality, argues Morin, but a hegemonic assumption of rationality leads to a rationalized, dogmatic and closed reasoning. Hence there are good epistemological reasons for keeping the dialogic open and each side ‘in check’ by the built-in antagonisms, says Morin, because there are pitfalls on each side of the delicate and uncertain construction of knowledge. This dialogic of empathic understanding and logical reasoning can, according to Morin, be broken down into a number of constituent dialogics. As he writes: ‘The thought, in its organizing/creative movement, is a complex dialogic of activities and operations which engages the complementary/antagonistic competences of the mind/brain’ (Morin, 1986: 182). As illustrated in the central column in Figure 1 below, this indicates ‘the complex character of the act of thinking; it evokes perpetually in itself in a complementary way virtually antagonistic processes which otherwise would tend to exclude each other’ (Morin, 1986). CCT arguably took a giant leap towards expansion beyond a few marginalized scholars through the courageous endeavor of an Odyssey. Hence, it is only too obvious to invite contemporary CCT scholars to consider their process of thinking as an ‘uninterrupted dialogical dynamism, a navigation between the contrary Scylla’s and Charybdis’s towards which the thought will be drawn by any hegemony of one side of its antagonistic processes’ (Morin, 1986). Knowledge must then be constituted through the complex dialogic of its constituting antagonisms. This dialogic, then, engages the oscillation between analysis (of parts) and synthesis (of the whole), between the particular and the general, between the empirical (based on observation) and the rational (based on logic).

However, as indicated by the parable of Scylla and Charybdis, knowledge must always toe the line and keep engaging its antagonistic forces. Rather than an equilibrium, it is for Morin a matter of a recursive process or, as he puts it, a whirlwind of constant regulation. To the extent that this regulation is not successful, knowledge degrades and falls into one of the pitfalls indicated in the left and right columns of the figure.

In a CCT context, the reasoning behind the rise of interpretivism in the 1980s can be seen as a move towards the left side of this figure in an attempt to challenge models of knowledge that strove for logical, detached and verifiable explanations of consumer behavior. The latter would sacrifice insights into consumer realities for theoretically precise and (oftentimes) mathematically abstract descriptions, which left very little flesh and blood on the portrait of consumers (Thompson et al., 1989). That the CCT tradition is in itself a scene for such dialogues among

paradigms is evident in for example the discussion of researcher participation illustrated by the debate pro (Gould, 1991) and contra (Wallendorf and Brucks, 1993) introspection as a legitimate method within CCT research.

Applying the dialogics of Morin to the history of CCT research, we would argue that the need to bring consumers alive as real people; and that an individualistic operationalization of the phenomenological tradition in consumer research has lead the CCT field to a situation where it sometimes applies an overly comprehension-oriented approach to consumer experiences. In an understandable reaction to the objectivism of the correlation coefficient hegemony, CCT research has employed an occasionally too comprehensive and subjectivist approach, where informants' experiential outpourings about their consumption whereabouts are not, or only to a small extent, interpreted and/or criticized against alternative explanatory or motivational frameworks. Consequently, the application of macro-systemic and social theoretical concepts for understanding the lifeworlds of consumers that go beyond what can immediately be detected in consumer accounts of lived experiences have been the exception rather than the rule.

What we are arguing here is (obviously, we hope) not a return to the 'normal science' period advocated by logical empiricists in the early debates concerning the interpretive turn in consumer research (cf. Østergaard and Jantzen, 2000). Nor do we wish to engage in the compelling debate on the possibilities of overcoming paradigmatic incommensurabilities (Davies and Fitchett, 2005; Tadjewski, 2008), since we consider ourselves to be at home in a broad constructivist tradition, which does not preclude visiting other paradigms and being inspired by the ways of their inhabitants. This article is not a critique of the multiple methods adopted and applied with great success by contemporary CCT researchers – nothing could be further from our agenda than establishing an *a priori* delimitation of the plethora of expressions of consumer culture and its behavioral practices that the CCT researchers have introduced over the last two decades, including videographies, poems, performances, stereoscopies and more. For reasons of boundary expansion, we strongly favor these ventures and explorations, even if we do not always find all such ventures eventually fruitful. What we do want to point out is the need for investigating the social institution of consumption and how it shapes our lives and choices beyond our individual identity projects. This will provide stronger explanatory frameworks in a number of CCT studies and rid the field of its worst solipsistic tendencies.

Our discussion has obvious linkages to the debate about relationships between contexts and theoretical insights in CCT research (Arnould et al., 2006). Like Arnould and his co-authors, we acknowledge the importance as well as the dangers of researcher immersion in the context. But we also think that we draw attention to an additional fact: whereas their purpose is to reflect on how variations in (emic) context generate possibilities for different theoretical (etic) contributions, as well as the tight relationship between emic and etic conceptualization, we advocate for more degrees of freedom in terms of applying etic constructs that are not readily traceable in the emic context to the interpretation etic constructs. We hope that by introducing the notion of context of contexts and rooting it in a Morinian dialogic, we have sustained a sufficiently solid argument for such daring theoretical leaps, not of faith but of interpretation.

It should thus be clear that we are not arguing for turning CCT research into a business-school based section of the sociology of consumption. The strength of CCT research in contemporary contributions to understanding consumer culture is exactly its ability to base its vast majority of insights on rich descriptions based on (largely qualitative) empirical research on consumers' lived experiences as well as their living conditions. We are thus skeptical about a use of theory that negates consumers as agentic components of the market system. As noted by Thompson (2007:

122) in his endorsement of Eric Schlosser's analysis of the American fast-food industry, *Fast Food Nation*, we should acknowledge

the importance and realpolitik value of investigating a defined market system within commercial culture, rather than making sweeping generalizations that presupposes the operation of a singularly dominant ideology (e.g. McDonaldization) or pathological zeitgeist (e.g. affluenza). Teasing out these complexities calls for muckraking scholarship that unpacks critical institutional details about how a market system functions and the specific effects that emanate from its organizational structures and processes.

These specific effects, we may add, are not least found in the daily life and consumption conditions as they are lived by the people (in their roles as consumers) that we investigate.

In the context of the structure–agency debate, then, our reflections here should not be taken as a dismissal of consumer agency, but rather as a word of warning against letting contemporary individualism, whether it expresses the ideologies of the cold war period (Tadajewski, 2006a); humanist psychology and its influence on an American popular culture of self-actualization (Illouz, 2008); or contemporary neoliberalism (e.g. Shankar et al., 2006; Zwick et al., 2008) overshadow the notion that the human being is first and foremost a social and cultural animal. Consumers consistently navigate, but only to a limited degree conduct, let alone create, the social universe of meanings that attach to consumer goods and practices – and then most often according to a score that they have not written themselves.

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